



bus driver myself," he says. "I am just going to get some breakfast while my wife is shopping. Don't worry, if you are still struggling when I come out, I will take you to Old Trafford in my car; it is just 15 minutes away."

But he comes out of the restaurant soon and still finds you waiting for the bus. "Come on, let me take you to Old Trafford in my new car," says the tall, bearded man. "I can't leave you here in a strange city."

You politely refuse. He insists. And off you go (as they frequently say here). Before taking up driving as a career, Darren had been in the army and served in Iraq and Afghanistan. "I was there when they caught Saddam Hussein," he says.

Though he watches cricket, he is basically a football fan, like most Englishmen. So you talk about

England's campaign at the World Cup. He is hopeful of England's chances under coach Thomas Tuchel. When you tell him that you interviewed Tuchel back in India, he is excited. "Oh My God," he says. "It is an honour for me to drive you, sir!"

Talking of kindness in strange lands, you still remember the young female manager at the hotel in Cape Town during the Indian men's team's Test tour in 2023-24. By the time you get back to the hotel, the restaurant has closed, and there is no eatery anywhere nearby. The manager asks you to get into her car and takes you to a fast-food joint that stays open late into the night. You are glad that she lets you buy some food for her and her little daughter, who has to wait longer for her that night.

Warm welcome: Every World Cup has its own colours. At Old Trafford, they began with Emirates red before giving way to a sea of India blue.

P. K. AJITH KUMAR

At Old Trafford, you cannot miss Emirates. The Dubai-based airline is the naming rights sponsor, and the ground is now officially called Emirates Old Trafford. So, you are greeted by two air hostesses from Emirates as you enter the ground.

"We are here to promote Emirates," says Alexandra, smiling, even as a large number of Indian fans, wearing blue, stream in.

The Women in Blue would, of course, lose that match to South Africa. You suspect it just might cost them dearly in the Group of Death.